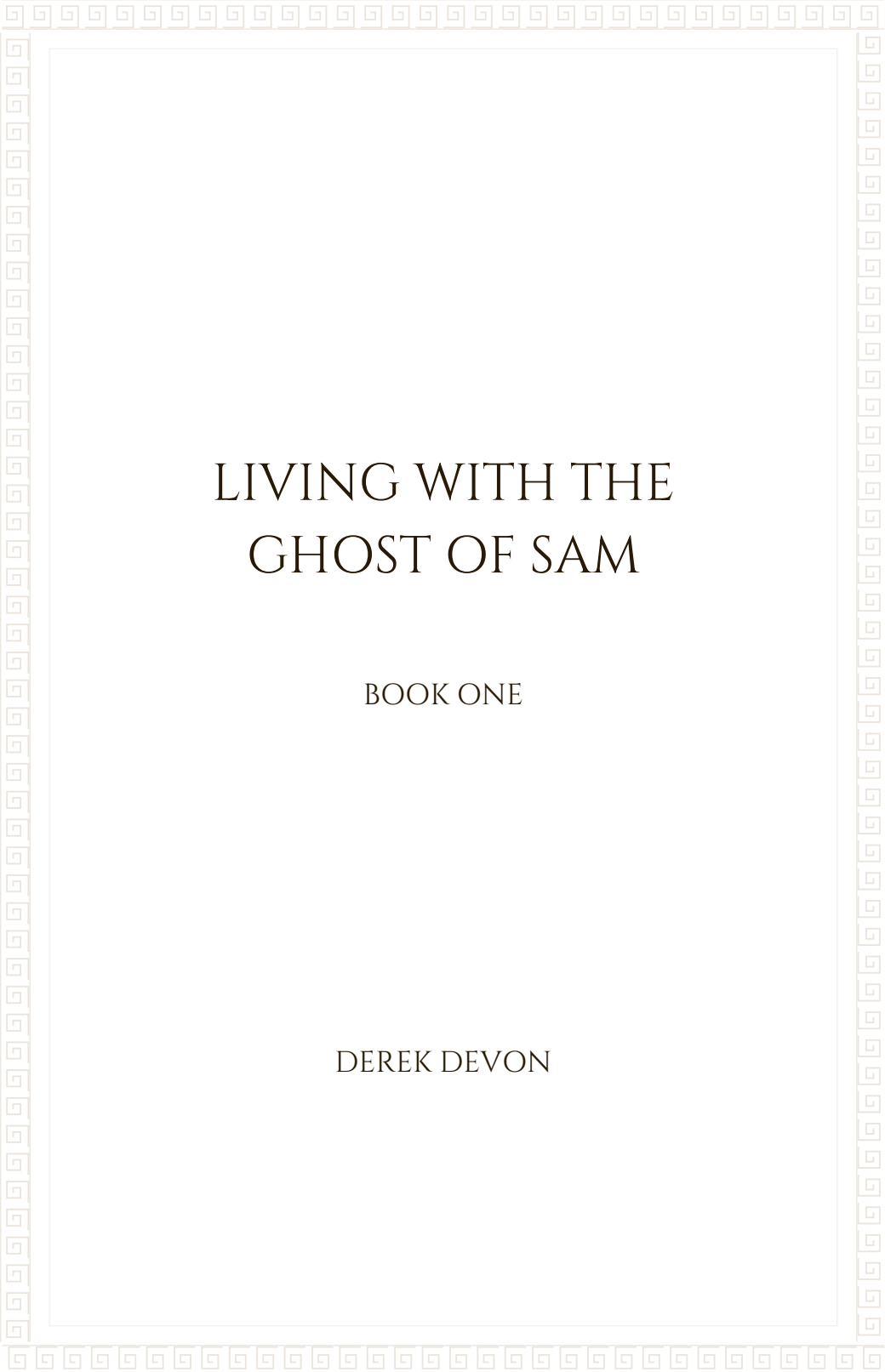




LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM

BOOK ONE

DEREK DEVON

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For Sam Kinison
(1953–1992)

who proved that a scream could be a love language,
and that the loudest voice in the room
could carry the biggest heart.

The story is fiction.
The laughter it chases was real.

OH... OH... OHHHHH.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — [Title]

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — [Title]

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two

CHAPTER 1

THE MORNING EVERYTHING CHANGED

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline...

The voice—if it was a voice—drifted somewhere between the stars and the atmosphere, too faint to be heard by the two astronauts floating in the cupola of the International Space Station. One of them pointed down at the blue curve of the Pacific coast, where San Francisco lay wrapped in its morning fog like a city that had hit snooze on itself. From up there, the bridges were silver threads. The traffic was a rumor. Everything looked peaceful.

Everything, from a sufficient distance, always does.

Down through the clouds, past the bridges, past the hills, past the eternally doomed search for parking and the ever-climbing price of sourdough, sat a row of tightly packed townhouses in the Marina District. And inside one of them, at exactly 5:45 a.m., an alarm clock was about to commit an act of cosmic timing.

BEEP-BEEP-BEEP.

The radio kicked in mid-broadcast, the DJ's voice cutting through the dark bedroom: "...and on this day in 1992, we lost comedy legend Sam Kinison..."

Derek Kinison's hand came down on the alarm hard enough to make it a warning to all future alarms. He sat up, disoriented, heart going for no reason he could name. In the dresser mirror across the room, his reflection caught him—and for a split second, it wasn't quite his. The eyes were wilder. The grin was wider. The face looking back belonged to a man who had once made entire theaters check their drink orders and their life choices simultaneously.

Derek blinked hard, and it was gone. Just a thirty-eight-year-old marketing executive with pillow creases on his cheek and a presentation at nine.

Beside him, his wife stirred. Nancy Hammond—she'd kept her name over his mother's objections, one of the many small battles she'd won with a smile—let out the little morning grunt she would deny making until her dying day.

Derek gave her a gentle elbow. "Hey, cute stuff. Time to move that awesome ass."

"Five minutes more, pleaseeeee." She rolled onto her stomach and pulled the covers over her head, a tactical retreat perfected over years of marriage.

Derek stared at the ceiling. "Did you hear thunder a few seconds ago?"

"Probably your stomach," came the muffled reply. "I told you those extra-hot Brassie wings would come back to haunt you."

Haunt. Funny choice of word. He filed it away and got up.



In the bathroom, Derek stood before the mirror in his perfectly pressed suit and practiced his presentation smile. It was a good smile. Focus-grouped, essentially. The problem was that this morning it kept slipping—the corners pulling wider than intended, the eyes going bright with something that had no business in a quarterly review.

"Quarterly projections," he muttered at his reflection. "Vertical integration. Synergy optimization."

The words tasted like drywall.

"You're talking to yourself again." Nancy appeared in the doorway, already dressed in gallery-chic, already halfway into her

own day.

"Big presentation today."

"You said that yesterday." She met his eyes in the mirror. "And the day before. And the day before that."

He straightened his tie with mechanical precision, each small adjustment betraying a growing irritation with the corporate uniform he'd spent fifteen years earning the right to wear. Nancy watched him a beat longer than usual, then went to deal with her lipstick and her phone, which was already buzzing with gallery business. In the kitchen the coffee maker gurgled to life, steam rising like the morning fog outside. Another day in the machine, warming up.

Except the machine, this particular morning, had developed a slight rattle.



Sunlight streamed through the kitchen windows, illuminating the demilitarized zone where Nancy's artsy decorating touches met Derek's meticulously organized everything. Nancy poured coffee with one hand and answered her phone with the other.

"Sophie? What do you mean the Rothschild piece is delayed?" A pause. Her free hand found her temple. "No, we need it for tonight's opening... The artist is *where?*"

Behind her, the toaster—an appliance with no history of ambition—suddenly launched both slices of toast high into the air, with a violence that could only be described as enthusiastic.

Derek caught both pieces without looking up from his tablet.

Nancy stopped mid-conversation and stared at him. He continued reading, buttering, entirely unaware that he'd just performed a small miracle of hand-eye coordination.

"Since when are you David Copperfield?" she said, covering the phone.

"Magic's all about timing, baby." He turned a page. "Speaking of which—can you grab dinner tonight? The board wants to review the Q3 projections again."

Nancy returned to the phone. "No, Sophie, not you... Yes, I know it's the centerpiece... Just—handle it." She hung up and exhaled. "Actually, I might be late too. Gallery crisis."

"Ah. The classic 'my art will be ready when it's ready' crisis?"

"More like 'my art is currently in a Tahitian jail' crisis."

They gathered briefcases and travel mugs in the practiced synchronization of two people who had been sharing a kitchen for a decade, and headed for the door.

They passed it every morning: the large framed photograph that dominated one wall of the living room. Young Derek—five years old, all ears and elbows—sitting on Sam's lap backstage at the Comedy Store, both of them caught mid-laugh, Sam's beret slightly askew, his arm around his little cousin like a seatbelt against the whole world. The family had all called him Uncle Sam, cousin or not; some people are simply uncles by force of personality. Derek kept a miniature of the same photo on his office desk, where it had long ago become invisible to him, the way anything does when you look at it every day without seeing it.

But this morning, his eyes lingered on Sam's face a moment longer than usual.

The photo, being a photo, did not wink back.

Probably.



The Tesla crawled along the bay with the rest of the morning traffic, fog clinging to the city's shoulders like a damp security blanket. A BMW cut across two lanes without signaling, missing their bumper by a coat of paint.

"Thanks for the signal, pal," Derek said under his breath—and then he laughed. Except it wasn't his laugh. It was raw and untamed, half growl, half delight, the kind of laugh that starts in the chest and ends somewhere in the back row.

Nancy looked up from her phone. "What was that?"

"What was what?"

"That laugh. It sounded just like..." She trailed off, shook her head, and went back to her email. Some sentences are better left unparked.

Derek's knuckles whitened on the wheel. His phone rang; the dashboard display lit up: CHARLES WEBER — CEO. He let it ring. It rang again: OFFICE — VP SALES. Also ignored. The parade of incoming calls had all the subtlety of a laugh track.

"Rerouting due to traffic," the GPS announced, with the serene confidence of a machine that has never once been stuck on Van Ness.

The new route took them down a street Derek hadn't driven in years, past the old Comic Strip club—boarded up now, its windows blind, its faded marquee still stubbornly legible after three decades of fog and neglect:

COMING SOON — SAM KINISON — APRIL 1992

Coming soon. The words hung there, a promise the universe had never gotten around to canceling. Derek's eyes stayed on the marquee longer than they should have, long enough that Nancy glanced over.

The radio crackled with static. And underneath the static—faint, impossible, unmistakable to anyone who had grown up with it echoing through family barbecues—a laugh. *That* laugh. Three rising notes of pure comic detonation.

Derek reached over and snapped the radio off. In the rearview mirror, just for an instant, the face looking back at him wore a beret.

He adjusted the mirror. Just fog. Just traffic. Just a man driving his wife to work on an ordinary Thursday that happened to be the anniversary of the day comedy lost its loudest voice.

Nancy, oblivious, was scrolling through gallery photos. "That new piece I mentioned? It's a painting of this incredible 1900s mansion in Cape Cod. Reminds me of that inn we were looking at up the coast."

"Mm," Derek said, from somewhere else entirely.

"Earth to Derek?" She studied him. "You've been somewhere else all morning."

"Just... thinking about changes."

"Changes?" Her eyes narrowed with the precision of a woman appraising a suspect provenance. "Derek Kinison, are you having an early midlife crisis?"

"Crisis implies I don't know what I'm doing." The timing on the line was immaculate. It wasn't entirely his.

Overhead, thunder rumbled through a cloudless sky, and neither of them mentioned it.



La Pierre Gallery rose out of the streetscape in glass and steel, looking exactly like the kind of place where art went to be taken seriously. Derek pulled up to the curb. Through the gallery

windows, art handlers were easing a crate open—glimpses of an ornate golden frame visible through the slats.

Nancy gathered her things, checked her tablet one final time, then leaned over and kissed his cheek, lingering a moment as she studied his distant expression in the rearview mirror.

"Remember, dinner at seven? I should be done with the new installation by then."

Derek was staring forward, his hands gripping the wheel with unnecessary force. "Sure. Yeah. Seven."

She got out, heels clicking decisively on the concrete, and turned back once—concern crossing her face as she watched her husband not quite watch her go. Then she was gone, swallowed by the glass doors and the Rothschild crisis and the ordinary machinery of her day.

Derek sat at the curb a moment longer than he needed to. Through the gallery's front window, he could see the handlers lifting the new piece free of its crate: a Victorian mansion on a coastal cliff, all turrets and shadows and windows like knowing eyes. Cape Cod, Nancy had said. It didn't look like Cape Cod. It looked like an appointment. He couldn't have said why the shadow it cast seemed, from this angle, to be shaped a little like a man in a beret.

The light changed. The Tesla merged back into traffic, carrying Derek Kinison toward a corporate tower, a boardroom, and slide number forty-seven of a presentation that would change everything.

Somewhere—in whatever cosmic comedy club the dead legends hang out in—somebody was checking the mic.

The morning was just getting started. And the universe, patient as any good comic, was setting up its punchline.

CHAPTER 2

HOW TO DO A CORPORATE MELTDOWN

The lobby of Global Dynamics Marketing looked like what would happen if an architect was asked to design purgatory, given an unlimited budget, and told to make it inspirational. Everything gleamed in that particular shade of off-white that screamed *we paid too much for this*. Motivational posters lined the walls, each more aggressively uplifting than the last. SYNERGY IS SUCCESS, proclaimed the largest, in a font that had never once been funny.

Derek nodded to the security desk on autopilot, a gesture so rehearsed he probably performed it in his sleep. The elevator arrived with a cheerful ding that felt, this morning, like mockery.

Inside, he was alone with his reflection in the polished steel doors. Except he wasn't, quite. The face looking back had his features, but the expression—that wild-eyed, delighted, slightly dangerous grin—belonged to somebody else. Derek blinked hard, the way people do when they're trying to reset either their vision or their entire reality.

His reflection tilted its head. Just the way Sam used to, right before launching into one of his legendary rants. And then it mouthed something. Three syllables. Rising.

The doors opened before Derek could decide whether he'd actually seen it, and the executive floor swallowed him whole—a maze of cubicles that would have made Kafka reach for something stronger than coffee. Young executives whispered their presentations into reflective surfaces like monks rehearsing corporate liturgy. *Our Q4 projections show significant upside potential...*

Charles Weber materialized out of the maze, tablet in hand, moving with the caffeinated polish of a CEO who had long ago replaced sleep with quarterly targets. Charles wasn't a bad man. That was the complicated part. He was a good man who had been in the machine so long he'd started to hum at its frequency.

"Big day, Derek. Board's expecting something revolutionary."

"Revolutionary?" Derek's head tilted—that tilt again. "Is that what we're calling PowerPoint these days?"

Charles laughed, a half-second too late and a half-note too high. "There's the Kinison humor. Just like your cousin, right?"

Derek's smile faltered. Somewhere—fifty floors up, indoors, impossibly—thunder rumbled.

His office was the museum of a successful life: awards, certifications, framed proof that Derek Kinison had done everything right. And on the desk, small enough to ignore, the photograph. Five-year-old Derek on Sam's lap, both of them mid-laugh at something the camera never caught. The miniature twin of the one at home. He'd walked past both of them ten thousand times.

He picked it up. He couldn't have said why.

"Board room in five, Mr. Kinison!" his secretary called.

Derek set the photo down, straightened his tie—too tight, suddenly—loosened it, tightened it again. In the window's reflection, for just a moment, a man in a business suit and a beret straightened his own tie mockingly, a metal button gleaming on his lapel. Derek didn't look closely enough to read it. If he had, it would have said: WELCOME TO THE LAUGH ASYLUM.

He walked to the boardroom. His footsteps seemed to get louder as he went, the ambient office noise fading away until there was only the sound of his own shoes and his own breathing, like the

world was clearing its throat before an announcement.



The boardroom was sleek and modern and dominated by a mahogany table large enough to declare war on. Floor-to-ceiling windows offered a panoramic view of San Francisco that nobody ever looked at. On the screen, slides full of graphs and jargon glowed with the confidence of numbers that had been massaged until they relaxed.

Derek sat rigidly, laptop open, sweat beginning at his hairline as the voices around him blurred into a single corporate drone.

"And as you can see from the quarterly projections," Charles was saying, "our vertical integration strategy..."

Derek's hands began to tremble. Fifteen years of these meetings. Fifteen years of nodding at slides. Somewhere in his chest, something was pulling tight—a guitar string winding past its tuning.

"Does anyone here know," he said, quietly, "who my uncle Sam was?"

The room fell silent. A field of confused faces, most of them belonging to executives who hadn't been born yet when Sam died.

A young exec leaned toward his colleague. "Who's Uncle Sam?"

The colleague shrugged. "Some old comedian, I think?"

Some old comedian.

Something snapped. Not broke—snapped. Like the string finally going, like a comedian finding his voice after a fifteen-year sound check.

"SOME OLD COMEDIAN?" Derek was on his feet, his chair rolling back with a sound like thunder. And then it *was*

thunder—real thunder, rattling the windows fifty floors above the street, under a sky the forecast had sworn was clear. The lights flickered. "OH! OH! OHHHH!"

The scream came out of him fully formed, three rising notes of pure detonation, a sound Derek Kinison had never made in his life and had somehow been rehearsing since 1992.

The room sat frozen. Then, because corporate instinct dies harder than dignity, the VP of Sales cleared his throat and attempted a rescue: "As you can see from slide forty-seven, our vertical integration strategy—"

"If we leverage our synergistic opportunities—" another exec began.

Each buzzword landed on Derek like a heckle. His tie came all the way loose and hung there like a surrender flag—except Derek had never felt less like surrendering in his life.

"My cousin Sam used to SCREAM his comedy into existence," he said, and his voice wasn't entirely his own anymore—it was rawer, bigger, truer. "Everybody thought he was crazy." He laughed, that wild laugh from the car, and it filled the room in a way the acoustic paneling was specifically engineered to prevent. "He wasn't crazy. He just saw through all the—" he gestured at the glowing slides like he was shooing away flies, "—THIS!"

"Derek." Charles's voice had gone very calm, the tone of a man talking someone off a ledge he had personally helped build. "Maybe you should take a moment to—"

But Derek was past moments. He walked over to Charles and slowly leaned down, head tilted at that angle that belonged on a stage, and when he spoke it was a perfect Kinison impression—pitch, cadence, and detonation—that made several executives physically jump.

"You ever wonder why we do all this crap? Why we act like uppity important executives while hard-working people went over to Vietnam up to their necks in rice paddies, shooting those North Korean gooks, giving their lives—so we can make some PowerPoint presentation? OH! OH! OHHHHHHH!"

The lights flickered again. Through the windows, storm clouds were assembling over a city that had been promised sunshine.

"Fifteen years!" Derek was building now, riding the crescendo. "Fifteen years of PowerPoints and synergy and vertical integration! For WHAT?!" He tore his tie the rest of the way off and threw it onto the mahogany like a gauntlet. "To sit here pretending any of this matters?"

Maureen Hamlin, VP of Client Relations, rose halfway out of her chair with the nervous grace of a hostage negotiator. "Derek, let's just take a breath and—"

"No, Maureen." Derek's voice dropped into an eerie calm, which was somehow louder than the screaming. "No more breaths. No more meetings. No more... whatever this is." He gestured at the room, the screen, the entire fluorescent ecosystem. "I'm done."

Somewhere in the office beyond the glass walls, somebody snorted. Somebody else didn't quite suppress a laugh. The young exec who'd said *some old comedian* was staring at Derek with the expression of a man watching his first live comedy show and his first workplace incident simultaneously.

"Derek," Charles tried again, "think about your future. Your security—"

"Security." Derek said the word like it was the punchline he'd been building to his whole life. "I spent fifteen years building a fortress out of security, Charles. Mortgage. Retirement plan. Dental. And you know what I found when I finished building it?" He picked up his laptop, closed it gently, almost tenderly, like closing a casket.

"I was inside."

He walked to the door. Stopped. Turned—because some exits are genetic—and gave the room a deep, theatrical bow. Sam's bow, executed to the millimeter.

"I quit. And by the way—" he pointed at the screen, at slide forty-seven, still glowing faithfully, "—your projections are wrong. They're ALWAYS wrong."



Packing a career into a cardboard box takes less time than the career suggests it should. Awards. Certifications. The little framed photo of Sam, which went in last, face up.

Derek's phone buzzed the entire time, the notifications stacking like a laugh track: *Meeting in chaos. Did you just QUIT? HR needs to speak with you immediately. LinkedIn: 25 people viewed your profile.*

And then one more, from Charles: *Think about your future, Derek. About security. About what matters.*

Derek laughed out loud—that laugh again—alone in his office with a box. Because that was exactly the point, wasn't it? He *was* finally thinking about what mattered. It had just taken a dead comedian and a public meltdown to schedule the meeting.

He hoisted the box and found his secretary standing at the office door, defensive and nervous, a woman whose job description had not covered this.

"What do you want me to do, Mr. Kinison?"

Derek turned to her in what felt like slow motion, wearing a smile that was warm and wild in equal parts. "You can take the rest of the day off. Get yourself a manicure. Maybe grab some lunch at Jake's Boathouse Bar and Grill. And after lunch, catch a matinee—I hear they're showing an old classic. 'Savage Dawn.'" He let out that

laugh again, the one that had been escaping all morning.

At the elevator, he stepped in, turned, and—as the doors began to close on fifteen years of his life—delivered his exit line with a creepy, beatific, entirely Sam-like smile:

"Daddy's on sabbatical!"

Down in the lobby, security personnel were already murmuring urgently into their radios—"He's here... sir, we need you to exit the building"—as Derek crossed the marble with his box, entirely unhurried. Marcus—the security guard who had nodded to Derek every morning for a decade without either of them really seeing the other—looked up from his desk.

"You okay there, Mr. Kinison?"

Derek stopped. Actually looked at him. "You know something, Marcus? I don't think I've been okay for fifteen years." He shifted the box to one hip. "But I'm starting to be."

The lobby's ambient music system chose that exact moment to shuffle onto a new track, and the opening riff of "Wild Thing" came grinding out of speakers that normally dispensed nothing stronger than smooth jazz. Marcus frowned at the ceiling. Derek just grinned and pushed through the revolving doors, and as he stepped out into the San Francisco morning, he could have sworn he heard a familiar voice riding under the music:

About time you woke up, cousin. About time.



In the parking garage, Derek put the box in the trunk, sat in the driver's seat, and gripped the wheel until his knuckles went white. The adrenaline was draining now, leaving behind the arithmetic: no job, one mortgage, a wife at a gallery who didn't yet know her husband had detonated his career before ten a.m.

"What the hell did I just do?" he whispered to the rearview mirror.

The face looking back wore an expression that was equal parts terror and exhilaration. "What the hell did I just do?" he asked it again—and this time the question came out as a laugh. Sam's laugh. It filled the car like a prophecy.

His phone lit up one more time. Not the office. His home security app: *Unusual activity detected — master bedroom mirror, camera glitch, review footage?* Derek almost dismissed it. Then he saw the timestamp.

5:45 a.m.

The exact minute his alarm had introduced the anniversary of Sam Kinison's death.

Derek stared at the notification for a long moment. Then he put the phone face-down on the passenger seat, started the car, and pulled out into traffic.

He needed to see Nancy.

Behind him, the Global Dynamics tower shrank in the mirror, fifty floors of security getting smaller and smaller until it could have fit in a cardboard box.

END OF SAMPLE

The house is just getting warmed up.

Read the complete Book One — and join the release list for the rest of the
series — at

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca